# Historical source

Encyclopaedia Britannica scan, source row 2448. Parse 3.5 extracted the text. Super 3.5 VL corrected it from an enlarged crop of each block. It can still contain recognition errors. Page headers, footers, and page numbers are removed.

## Untitled continuation (E0219)

*Continues an entry from an earlier page.*

makes one of a group, and thinks in wretched unanimity with the throng. Incumbered with the notions of others, and impoverished by their abundance, he conceives not the least embryo of new thought; opens not the least vista through the gloom of ordinary writers, into the bright walks of rare imagination, and singular design; while the true genius is cropping all public roads into fresh untrodden ground, he, up to the knees in antiquity, is treading the faded footsteps of great examples, with the blind veneration of a bigot fawning the papal toe; comfortably hoping full absolution for the sins of his own understanding, from the powerful charm of touching his idol's infallibility.

Such meanings of mind, such profession of our own powers, proceeds from too great admiration of others. Admiration has generally a degree of two very bad ingredients in it; of ignorance, and of fear; and does mischief in composition, and in life. Proud as the world is, there is more superiority in it given, than assumed: and its grandee of all kinds owe more of their elevation to the littleness of others minds, than to the greatness of their own. Were not prostrate spirits their voluntary peddlers, the figure they make among mankind would not stand so high. Imitators and translators are somewhat of the peddler kind, and sometimes rather raise their original's reputation, by showing him to be by them inimitable, than their own. Homer has been translated into most languages; Elian tells us, that the Indians, (hopeful tutors!) have taught him to speak their tongue. What expect we from them? Not Homer's Achilles, but something, which, like Patroclus, assumes his name, and, at its peril, appears in his stead; nor expect we Homer's Ulysses gloriously bursting out of his cloud into royal grandeur, but an Ulysses under disguise, and a beggar to the left. Such is that inimitable father of poetry, and oracle of all the wise, whom Lycurgus transferred; and for an annual public recital of whole works Solon enacted a law; that it is much to be feared, that his so numerous translations are but as the published testimonials of so many nations, and ages, that this author to divine is untranslated still.

But here,

But hight, Cynthius aurem Vellit, and demands justice for his favourite, and ours. Great things he has done; but he might have done greater. What a fall is it from Homer's numbers, free as air, lofty and harmonious as the spheres, into childish fack- les, and tinkling founds! But, in his fall, he is full great;

Nor appears

Left than archangel ruin'd, and the excess Of glory obfeur'd.

Had Milton never wrote, Pope had been left to blame: but when in Milton's genius, Homer, as it were, personally rose to forbid Britons doing him that ignoble wrong; it is less pardonable, by that effeminate decoration, to put Achilles in petticoats a second time. How much nobler had it been, if his numbers had rolled on in full flow, through the various modulations of masculine melody, into those grandeurs of solemn sound, which are in

, into those grand divisions of tolemn found, which are in-

dispensibly demanded by the native dignity of heroic song? How much nobler, if he had refilled the temptation of that Gothic demon, which modern poetry talking, because moral! I don willke the doubtlets, divine harmony of three great names (how justly joined!) of Milton, Greece, and Rome? His verse, but for his little speck of mortality, in its extreme parts, as his hero had in his heel; like him, had been invulnerable, and immortal. But, unfortunately, that was undipt in Helicon; as this in Styx. Harmony as well as eloquence is essential to poetry; and a murder of his music is putting half Homer to death. Blank is a term of diminution; what we mean by blank verse is, verse unfallen, uncurled; verse reclaimed, reinthroned in the true language of the gods; who never thundered, nor suffered their Homer to thunder in rhyme.

But supposing Pope's Iliad to have been perfect in its kind; yet it is a translation still; which differs as much from an original, as the moon from the fun.

But as nothing is more easy than to write originally wrong; originals are not here recommended, but under the strong guard of the first rule,Know thyself. Lucian, who was an original, neglected not this rule, if we may judge by his reply to one who took some freedom with him. He was at first an apprentice to a statuary; and when he was reflected on as such, by being called Prometheus, he replied, "I am indeed the inventor of a new work, the model of which I owe to none; and, if I do not execute it well, I deserve to be torn by twelve vultures, instead of one."

Bacon fays, " Men seek not to know their own flock, and abilities; but fancy their poffeflions to be greater, and their abilities less, than they really are." Which is in effect saying, " That we ought to exert more than we do; and

that, on exertion, our probability of fuccelfs is greater than we conceive."

Nor have we Bacon's opinion only, but his affiance too, in savour of originals. His mighty mind travelled round the intellectual world; and, with a more than eagle's eye, few, and has pointed out, blank spaces, or dark spots in it, on which the human mind never shone: some of these have been enlightened since; some are benighted still.

Moreover, so boundless are the bold excursions of the human mind, that in the vast void beyond real existence, it can call forth shadowy beings, and unknown worlds, as numerous, as bright, and perhaps as flitting as the stars; such quite-original beauties we may call paradisiacal.

Natos fine feminine flores.

When such an ample area for renowned adventure in original attempts lies before us, shall we be as mere leaden pipes, conveying to the present age small streams of excellence from its grand reservoir in antiquity; and those too perhaps mudded in the pass? Originals shine like comets; have no peer in their path; are rivalled by none, and the gaze of all: all other compositions (if they shine at all) shine in clusters; like the stars in the galaxy; where, like bad neighbours, all suffer from all; each particular being diminished, and almost lost in the throng.

If thoughts of this nature prevailed; if ancients and moderns were no longer considered as masters and pupils,

## Source record

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